

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Decision

The email came on a Friday afternoon in the third week of March. Priya was at home. She had gotten home from school twenty minutes earlier. She was in her room. Hannah was in the next room — Hannah had come over after school the way Hannah had come over after school once a week since they were ten — and Hannah was on Priya's bed, on her phone, half-watching a video.

Priya was at her desk. Her laptop was open. She was, in some part of her, doing chemistry homework. She was, in another part of her, refreshing the email tab every three minutes.

The college had said it would release decisions at four p.m. Eastern. It was 3:58.

At 4:01, the email arrived.

Priya saw it in her inbox. The subject line was the school's name and Decision Available. Her hands started shaking. She had been waiting for this moment since November, when she had submitted the early action application. The school had deferred her in December. She had been waiting since December for the regular decision. Three months. The waiting had been a constant low-grade hum under everything she had done since winter break.

She did not open the email.

She turned around in her chair.

She said, Hannah.

Hannah looked up.

Priya said, it is here.

Hannah sat up. She put the phone down. She said, open it.

Priya said, I cannot open it. You open it.

Hannah said, Priya. I cannot open your college decision.
That is yours. You open it.

Priya said, Hannah. Please.

Hannah looked at her for a second. Then she got up and came over to the desk. She sat next to Priya. She said, okay.
We are going to do this

together. I am going to be right here. You are going to click the link. We are going to read it together. Okay?

Priya nodded.

She clicked the link.

The page loaded.

The page said Dear Priya, we are sorry to inform you.

Priya read it. She read it again. She read it a third time. The words kept being the same words. They were the words she had been afraid of since November. The school had said no.

She did not cry, at first. She just sat. She sat with her hand on the trackpad and the cursor blinking and the message saying we are sorry to inform you in the kind formal language admissions offices use. Hannah read it too.

Hannah said, Priya.

Priya did not say anything.

Hannah said, Priya, look at me.

Priya looked at her.

Hannah said, Priya. This is one school. This is one no. This is not about you.

Priya started crying.

Hannah hugged her.

Priya cried for maybe ten minutes. Hannah did not move. Hannah did not say anything. Hannah just held her.

When Priya could talk, she said:

Hannah. The Critic is going to use this. She is going to use this for a long time. She is going to say this is proof.

Hannah said, I know.

Priya said, I have been telling her to shut up about this for two years. About this exact thing. I told her, in November, that whatever they decided was not going to be a verdict on me. I told her that in February when she started in. I told her that yesterday morning. And now they have said no, and she is going to be the I told you so voice for the rest of senior year.

Hannah said, Priya. Listen to me.

Priya said, I am listening.

Hannah said:

Priya. The Critic gets to have this for one day. One day. We are going to give it to her. We are going to cry. We are going to be sad. We are going to let her have her I told you so victory lap. We are going to let her run around for a few hours.

Then, tomorrow, we are going to start the work of catching her on this one. Because she is going to try to make this evidence for everything else she has ever told you about yourself. That you are not smart. That you are a fraud. That the other schools that have said yes only said yes because they did not look carefully. That your real worth has just been confirmed by the one school you wanted most.

She is going to do all of that. She is going to do it for weeks. She is going to try to do it for the rest of your life.

We are going to catch her every time. Me. You. Sofia. Marcus. Amara. Hannah Park, even, the new girl in photography, who I do not know but who you can probably tell about this if you want to widen the circle. We are going to

catch her. We have been catching her for ten years. We are going to catch her on this one too.

Priya cried more.

She said, Hannah. Thank you.

Hannah said, Priya. I love you.

Priya said, I love you, Hannah.

They sat at the desk for a long time.

Eventually Hannah said, Pri, are you going to call your parents. Priya said, yes.

Hannah said, I am going to stay. I am going to be here when you call. I am not going to leave.

Priya called her mother first. Her mother was at work. Her mother picked up on the second ring. Priya said, Mom. The school said no. Her mother said, baby. Baby. I am so sorry. I am so sorry. Come home — you are home? Okay. I am coming home. I am leaving work now. Her mother came home twenty minutes later. Her father came home thirty minutes after that. Her mother had texted him on her way home. The three of them sat in the living room — Hannah was there too, because Hannah had insisted on staying — and her parents took turns saying the kind of things parents say in these moments. You are going to

be okay. The school did not see you the way we see you. You have other schools. We are proud of you. We love you.

Priya listened.

The Critic was, by 6 p.m., already in the back of Priya's head saying all of this is the parents-doing-their-job version of consolation. Real recognition would have come from the school. The parents are biased. The parents have to say this. The truth is they are disappointed too. They are just hiding it.

Priya caught the Critic.

She said, in her head, no. That is the Critic. That is not true. My parents are real. Their disappointment is in proportion. They love me. The love is not a job. They are not lying.

The Critic got quiet for a minute.

The Critic came back ten minutes later with a new line. They are pretending it is fine because they do not want you to feel worse. They are managing you.

Priya caught the Critic again.

She said, in her head, the parents who taught me to be a person who can read situations are not managing me. They are loving me. I can tell the difference.

The Critic, for the first time that night, went quiet for longer. Priya, sitting on the couch between her mother and her father, with Hannah across from them, breathed.

She breathed for a long time.

At dinner, her mother made her favorite food. Her father told a story about a time he had not gotten into a graduate program he had wanted, in his twenties, and how that not-getting had led him to a different program where he had met Priya's mother. He told the story not as a life lesson — her father was not the life lesson kind of father — but as a small piece of evidence that the closed door is sometimes part of a different opened door.

Priya laughed a little, for the first time since 4:01.

After dinner, she called Sofia.

Sofia, who had spent half a decade being the call-Sofia kid, was on the other end of the line for forty-five minutes. Sofia did the listening Sofia does. Sofia said, at the end, Priya. I am going to tell you something. Are

you ready?

Priya said, yes.

Sofia said:

The school you really wanted has just made the wrong call. They have just turned down a kid who would have made their freshman class better. That is on them, not on you. You are going to go to one of the other schools that has said yes, and you are going to be there in August, and the school you go to is going to get the version of you who has — for the rest of her life — the small private knowledge that one school said no, and that she went and did the work anyway.

The kid who is going to be in Boston in August is going to be a stronger kid for this. Not because the Critic is right. Because the Critic is wrong, and the catching of her on this one is going to make you faster at catching her on all the future ones.

This is one of the hardest gifts you have ever been given. I am not going to call it a gift right now. I am going to call it what it is — a hard thing. But in three years you will look back and you will see it differently. I love you. Get some sleep. Text me in the morning.

Priya said, Sof. Thank you. I love you.

She hung up.

She went to bed.

She did not sleep well. She lay there for hours. The Critic kept trying to come back with new versions of the I told you so. Priya kept catching her. The catching was tiring. The tiring was real. Priya had not slept well in two months because of waiting and now she was not going to sleep well for two more because of the processing. That was the work. The work did not care if you were tired.

In the morning, she opened the laptop again.

She did not look at the rejection email.

She looked at the two acceptance emails she had already received — one from a state school, one from a smaller liberal

arts college that had a strong creative writing department and that, when she had visited last summer, had felt — quietly — like a place she could be a different version of herself.

She looked at the liberal arts college's email for a long time.

She thought — okay. The Boston school does not want me. This school wants me.

She thought — and the Critic flinched a little here, the way she does — I have been carrying the Boston dream for two years. I am going to put it down. I am going to put it down on the floor tonight. I am going to walk into the liberal arts college's email and I am going to read it like the school I am going to.

She read it.

The school had offered her substantial financial aid. The school had also flagged her, in the email, for a small first-year honors program she would be invited to apply to.

She read the email again.

She thought — okay. Okay. This is going to be okay.

She did not, in the morning of the day after, feel like it was going to be okay. The morning of the day after was still raw. The Critic was still loud. The Boston dream was still in her head as the thing she had wanted. But she had — she now realized — a tool the Critic did not. She had the practice of catching the Critic. The practice had been built across ten years. The practice was going to work on this one. The practice was going to work on every future one. The Critic was going to keep showing up for the rest of her life. The practice was going to keep catching her. The catching, eventually, would be faster than the showing up. The Critic would, by the time Priya was thirty, be quieter than she had ever been. That was the lesson.

That was the lesson Ms. Calloway had given Priya in third grade, when Priya had been nine and had cried in a bathroom stall and had come out with three sentences in her pocket.

The three sentences were still in Priya's pocket today, ten years later, in a slightly different form.

This is loud. This is the Critic. This is not true.

Priya wrote, on a Post-it, that morning:

One school said no. Other schools said yes. The Critic is going to try to make this evidence. The Critic is not the evidence. The next four years are the evidence. I am going to live them.

She put the Post-it on her bathroom mirror.

She got dressed.

She went to school.

She told Marcus and Amara and Sofia, in the senior lounge during their shared free block. They listened. They did not say the wrong things. They were the cohort. They had been the cohort for twelve years. They knew what to say.

Marcus said, after a while, Priya. I want to tell you something. Are you ready?

Priya said, yes.

Marcus said, Priya, you are going to be the best version of yourself at whatever school you go to. Not because of the school. Because of you. The school is the building. You are the person who walks into the building. The person who walks in matters more than the building. Priya said, thank you, Marcus.

He said, I have been waiting to use that one. I have been working on it for a week.

Priya laughed.

The laughing was the first real laugh of the day after.

The day after the day after was a little easier.

The Critic was still there. She would always be there. But she was — already, twenty-four hours in — a little quieter than she had been the night the rejection came.

Priya was going to be okay.

She was going to go to the liberal arts college in August.

She was going to study English and possibly minor in creative writing or possibly minor in public policy, like Amara was thinking of doing — there were ideas to explore.

She was going to write to Mia, who had been her pen pal correspondent in pieces over the years. Mia, in Pittsburgh, was getting her own decisions in March. Priya wanted to know what Mia was doing. She was going to walk into Room 207 the next Monday and Ms.

Calloway, who knew, was going to nod at her and Priya was going to nod back. The cohort was going to keep going.

The Critic was loud.

The Critic was not true.

The Critic was small.

Priya was Priya. She was bigger than the Critic. She had always been bigger than the Critic. She just had to keep remembering.

The Post-it on the bathroom mirror was going to help with the remembering for the rest of senior year.

She was going to take it with her in August. It was going to go on the bathroom mirror of her dorm room.

She was going to keep remembering.

That is what Priya is.